...that we should go on with our present policy, but do it in a more ingratiating way; use rather nicer phrases and try to humour the Persian National Government more than the Government of India thinks that we have so far done, and that our better manners should take the form of repeating the statements we have already made in a pleasanter way...

Curzon then dismissed this argument by disparaging Indian expertise: 'it is to be noted that all the authorities who speak with actual knowledge of Persia itself are against it'. What Curzon advocated, in contrast, was a set of reforms and economic concessions which were to be pressed upon the Persian government. Should it refuse to accept such an arrangement, Persia would find itself cut off from any future British loans and would face an immediate call on all its current debts.[69] The British government, he argued, 'have never had the pluck to say to them [the Persians]. "You are in our hands absolutely to do as we please.' In his opinion, now was the time to tell the Persian government just that.[70]

The reality, however, was that Persia was not entirely in British hands. Despite Bolshevik proclamations renouncing all Russia's foreign interests and an official recall of all Russian staff from foreign soil, in 1918 there remained in Persia an imperial Russian presence in the form of the Russian Legation in Tehran and the Cossack Division. Officially, this Russian presence in Persia remained allied to Britain, and London had been financially supporting both organisations since 1917.[71] As Cox observed, however, there was a great difficulty in having in Persia so many Russian officials 'of [the] old regime who cannot exist without our support, but who not unnaturally resent our predominance...'[72] Both the leader of the Russian Legation, Vladimir Minorskii, and the commander of the Cossack Division, Colonel Staroselskii, regarded themselves as the last bulwark of Russia's presence in Persia. Both also felt responsible for maintaining a semblance of Russian influence in Tehran for as long as was necessary for a new Russian government to form and reclaim its privileges there.[73] For this Russian element, forced to watch Britain's international standing reach its pinnacle with the conclusion of the First World War while their country collapsed into anarchy and civil war, it was hard not to view their old Great